PART IV · HARMONY · 9

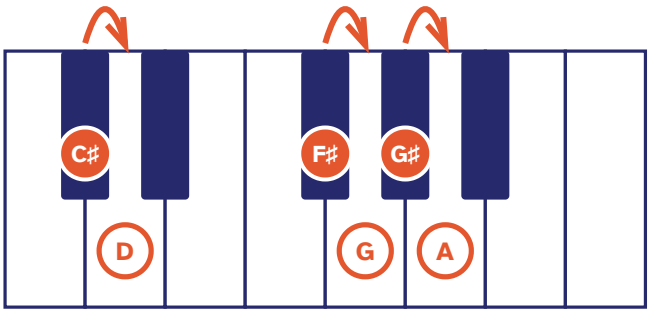
Chords from outside the key

C major lives on the white keys. A black key in a chord is a **guest**. Guests never stay: each one moves **one key**, and shows you where the music goes next.

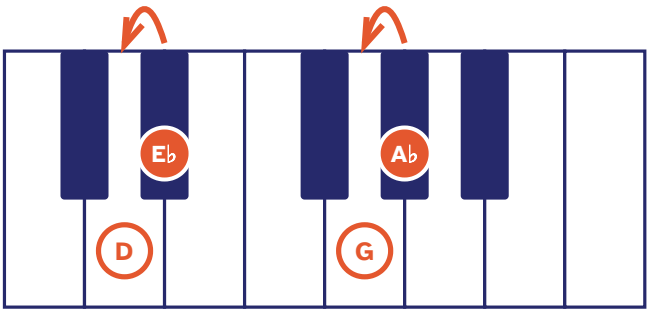
THE SECRET

Sharp guests push up, flat guests sigh down: follow them one key and you find the next chord.

Sharp guests push up

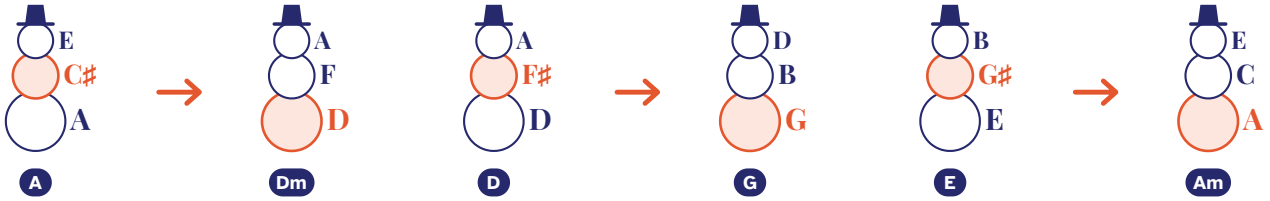


Flat guests sigh down

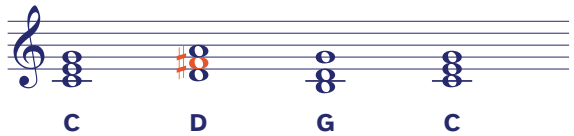


1. Find the **black key** in the chord: that is the guest.
2. A **sharp**? Go **up** one key. A **flat**? Go **down** one key.
3. You have found a note of the **next chord**. Play it and hear it land.

Sharp guests: up one key names the next chord

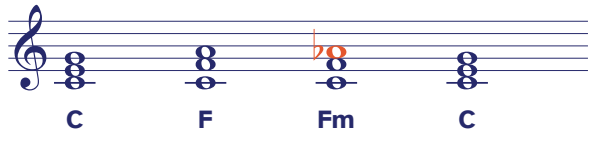


C♯ goes up to **D**, so the next chord is D minor. F♯ goes up to **G**: G. G♯ goes up to **A**: A minor.



Try it in a song: C, D, G, C. The **F♯** pushes up into G, then G leads home to C.

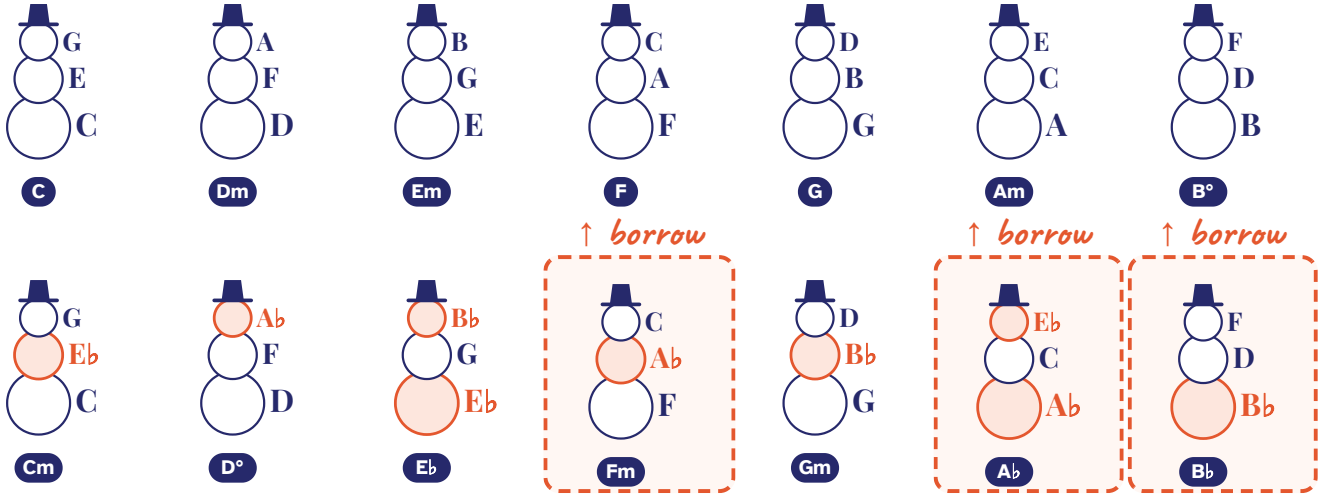
Flat guests: borrowed from the twin, they sigh down



C major and C minor are **twins**: the same home note, C, in different clothes. A flat guest is one piece of the twin's outfit. In C, F, Fm, C the **A♭** sighs down to G.

PART IV · HARMONY · 9 · CONTINUED

C major *at home*

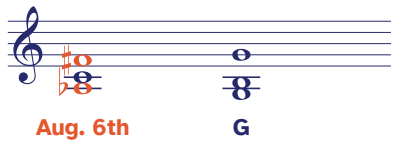


C minor *the twin: same home note, darker clothes*

Their names, for later

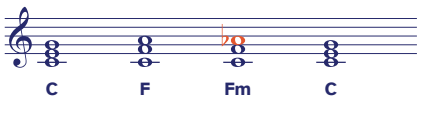
GUEST	NOTES	MOVES	NEXT CHORD	ITS NAME
sharp guest	D F♯ A	F♯ up to G	G	V of V
sharp guest	A C♯ E	C♯ up to D	Dm	V of ii
sharp guest	E G♯ B	G♯ up to A	Am	V of vi
flat guest	F A♭ C	A♭ down to G	C	borrowed iv
flat guest	A♭ C E♭	A♭ down to G	G or B♭	borrowed ♭VI
flat guest	B♭ D F	B♭ on to C	C	borrowed ♭VII

B♭ is the one flat guest that walks **up** instead, on to C: the rock and film ending B♭ → C. The bigger guests (the Neapolitan, Level 7) follow the same idea.



An advanced guest (Extra): the augmented 6th has two guests at once. The flat **A♭** falls and the sharp **F♯** rises, and both land on G. The rule still works.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play C, F, Fm, C slowly.

Hear the A♭ sigh down to G? Now play C, D, G, C: the F♯ pushes up instead. One sighs, one pushes.

PART IV · HARMONY · 9 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Find the guest: A C♯ E in C major



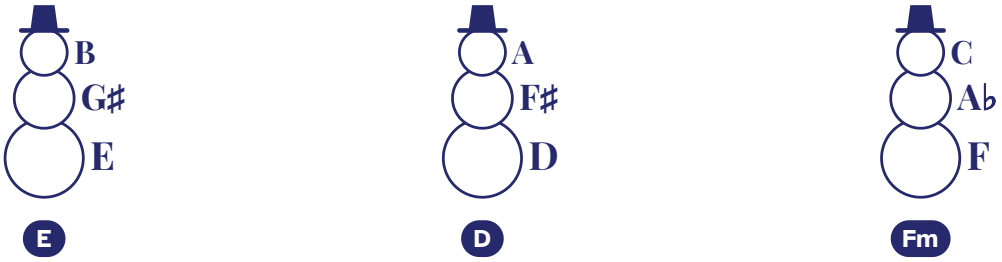
A C♯ E

1. **The black key:** C♯. That is the guest.
2. **It is a sharp,** so it goes up one key: to D.
3. **D names the next chord:** D minor (D F A).

A C♯ E leads to **D minor**. Play them one after the other and hear C♯ slide into D.

GAME

Where does the guest go?



In C major: find each guest, follow it one key, and write the chord that comes next.

Answer: 1 G♯ up to A: A minor · 2 F♯ up to G: G · 3 A♭ down to G: C.

THINK OF IT A surprise guest at dinner: one new face changes the whole conversation, and then everyone goes home.

TRAP

- × Following a sharp downwards: sharps push **up**, flats sigh **down**.
- × Learning the names first: play it, hear where the guest goes, then name it.
- × Mixing up the relatives: C minor is C major's twin (same home note). A minor is its neighbour (same key signature). We borrow from the twin.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 92 · Slash chords p. 107 · Cadences p. 113

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 9 · Online: Library › Chromatic chords